IELTS Listening Practice Test

Transcript — Parts 1–4 · Episode 4

PART 1

You will hear a man named Arthur calling Beatrice at a local community center to inquire about renting a room for a family gathering. You now have some time to look at questions 1 to 10.

Speaker B: Hello, community center bookings. This is Beatrice speaking. How can I help you?

Speaker A: Hi Beatrice. My name is Arthur. I'm calling to inquire about hiring a room for a family event. It's my grandmother's eighty-first birthday.

Speaker B: Oh, how lovely! We'd be happy to host that. What date were you looking at?

Speaker A: We're planning it for the fourteenth of October.

Speaker B: Let me check our calendar for October fourteenth... Yes, we have two spaces available then. We have the Oak Room and the Maple Room. The Maple Room is usually best for family parties because of its size.

Speaker A: That sounds perfect. I think we will go with the Maple Room.

Speaker B: Great. I'll make a note of that. And what type of event is it exactly? I know you mentioned a birthday, but on the form, I should write down whether it's a dinner, a dance, or a party.

Speaker A: Let's list it as a party. It'll be quite informal.

Speaker B: Excellent. And how many guests are you expecting?

Speaker A: We have invited fifty people, but we expect about forty-five to actually attend.

Speaker B: Okay, forty-five guests. And what time would you like the booking to start? The room is available from five o'clock.

Speaker A: Well, guests will arrive at seven, but we'll need some time to set up beforehand. Can we book the room to start at six thirty?

Speaker B: Yes, six thirty pm is fine. Do you require any specific equipment, like a microphone or a music system?

Speaker A: We'll have some family photos to display. Is there a projector we could use?

Speaker B: Yes, we can set up a projector for you at no extra cost. Now, regarding food, do you want us to provide a hot sit-down meal, or would you prefer a buffet?

Speaker A: A buffet would be much better for everyone to mingle.

Speaker B: Perfect. I'll make a booking reservation now. I need to give you a reference number. It is 7-8-4-2-9. Could you write that down?

Speaker A: Got it. 7-8-4-2-9.

Speaker B: And can I take a contact phone number for you, Arthur?

Speaker A: Yes, it's 0-7-7-0-0-9-0-0-1-2-3.

Speaker B: Let me repeat that: 0-7-7-0-0-9-0-0-1-2-3. Is that correct?

Speaker A: Yes, that's it.

Speaker B: Great. To secure the booking, we require a deposit. The total hire fee is four hundred pounds, but the deposit is just one hundred and fifty pounds, payable by the end of this week.

Speaker A: That's fine. I'll drop by tomorrow to pay that. Thank you, Beatrice!

Speaker B: You're very welcome, Arthur. See you tomorrow.

This is the end of Part 1.

PART 2

You will hear a local volunteer coordinator named Charles talking to a group of residents about a new community garden project in their town. You now have some time to look at questions 11 to 20.

Speaker A: Good evening, everyone. My name is Charles, and I'm delighted to see so many of you here tonight to learn about our new green-space project, the Millbrook Community Garden. Our primary aim here isn't to turn everyone into commercial farmers or to supply the big supermarkets in town. Nor are we intending to run academic courses to get people certified as professional horticulturists, though we will certainly share plenty of tips. Instead, our main objective is to create a vibrant, welcoming space where neighbors can meet, chat, and build stronger relationships while working outdoors together. The land we are using has an interesting history. Originally, we hoped the town council would let us use a plot behind the library, and we also approached the local primary school about their unused playing field. However, in the end, a local construction firm, which owns several plots around town, generously agreed to let us use this vacant site behind the high street for free for the next five years. We've had some questions about the commitment required from volunteers. Some people worry they don't have enough time. We don't expect anyone to give up all their weekends. While some community gardens ask for three or even four hours, we only ask that you commit to a minimum of two hours per week. You can split this time up however you like, whether it's a couple of short visits after work or one longer block on a Saturday morning. As for tools, you don't need to bring your own spades or rakes. We have acquired a good stock of equipment. Originally, we planned to store everything inside the nearby community center, but walking back and forth proved too inconvenient during our trial runs. We also looked into buying a wooden shed, but unfortunately, local planning rules made that difficult. Fortunately, we've managed to install a secure metal container right on the site, which is perfect for keeping our tools safe and dry. Now, what about the fruits and vegetables we grow? Once everything is harvested, our priority is to support those in need. Rather than selling the produce at a weekend market to raise funds, or dividing all of it strictly among our active volunteers, we have partnered with the local food bank. Every Thursday, we will deliver fresh, organic vegetables to them so they can distribute them to families in the area. Before we head out to look at the site, I need to go over a few safety rules for everyone working in the garden. First of all, safety is our top priority. The soil is generally clean, but there can be sharp objects or insects, so you must always wear strong boots while working in the soil to protect your feet. Sandals are definitely not permitted. Secondly, we have a lot of local wildlife, including rabbits and deer, who would love to eat our crops. To keep them out, please ensure that you keep the main gate closed at all times. Don't leave it propped open, even if you are just popping out to your car for a minute. We also want to keep track of what the garden is producing. So, whenever you pick any vegetables, please write down the weight and type of crop in the logbook that we keep on the shelf in the tool container. It's vital for our annual reports. Next, we are committed to being fully organic. Under no circumstances should you apply any chemical spray to the vegetables. If you notice pests, speak to me and we will use natural deterrents. Lastly, if you notice any broken tools, damaged fences, or other issues, please report them to the supervisor immediately. We want to keep the garden safe and functional for everyone. Thank you, and let's go see the site!

This is the end of Part 2.

PART 3

You will hear two university students named David and Edward discussing their presentation on renewable energy with their tutor, Fiona. You now have some time to look at questions 21 to 30.

Speaker C: Come in, David, Edward. Take a seat. How is your preparation going for next week's presentation on renewable energy?

Speaker A: Thanks, Fiona. To be honest, we're a bit stressed. We've done a lot of reading and gathered so much interesting data, but we're struggling to condense it all. We only have fifteen minutes, and right now, our draft is looking like it would take at least half an hour to get through.

Speaker B: Yes, we've already agreed on who is presenting which slide, and we're happy with our research. It's just the sheer volume of material that's the problem.

Speaker C: That's a very common issue. Let's look at your structure. Show me your slides. Okay, this introduction is very detailed, explaining the history of energy from the industrial revolution onwards. I think you should shorten this significantly. You only need a couple of sentences on the history before moving straight into modern challenges.

Speaker A: That makes sense. If we cut down the history, we'll save at least three minutes.

Speaker C: Exactly. Now, let's look at your sections on specific energy sources. You have a slide here on wind energy. What are you planning to focus on there, Edward?

Speaker B: Well, I know there's a lot of debate about the high cost of constructing these turbines, and some people are concerned about the danger they pose to local birds. But I think the most exciting development we should highlight is the massive potential of offshore wind farms, especially the new floating designs.

Speaker C: I agree, that's highly relevant and forward-looking. What about your visual aids? I see you've got several slides with heavy text and bullet points.

Speaker A: Yes, we thought bullet points would help the audience follow our main arguments.

Speaker C: Actually, having bullet points on every single slide can make your presentation look tedious and dry. Try to use more diagrams or photos, and only use text slides when absolutely necessary.

Speaker B: Okay, we can definitely swap some text for images. Should we include that short video clip we found? It's about two minutes long.

Speaker C: A two-minute video is too long for a fifteen-minute talk. Keep it to under thirty seconds, or don't use it at all.

Speaker A: Right, we'll edit the video down. What should we do after this meeting? Should we start working on the conclusion slide?

Speaker C: I think your conclusion outline looks fine as it is. What you really need to do next is actually run through the whole presentation from start to finish. Use a stopwatch to see exactly how long each section takes. That will tell you where you still need to cut details.

Speaker B: That sounds like a plan. We'll do a timed practice run tonight.

Speaker C: Great. Now, let's divide up the remaining research tasks for the specific energy sources we haven't finalized yet. We have five sources left: solar, geothermal, tidal, biomass, and hydroelectric. Let's decide who is taking the lead on each, or if you're both doing them.

Speaker A: Well, for solar energy, I've already collected all the recent statistics on solar panel efficiency, so I'll take full responsibility for finalizing that section.

Speaker B: That's fine. And I can handle geothermal power. I read a fascinating report on how Iceland utilizes geothermal energy, and I want to research how that model could be applied elsewhere.

Speaker A: What about tidal energy? That's quite a complex topic because of the engineering challenges in marine environments.

Speaker B: I think we should tackle that one together. Since we both need to understand the physics of underwater turbines to present it well, let's do joint research on tidal power.

Speaker A: Agreed, we'll both look into that. Now, biomass fuels—I know quite a bit about biofuel crops from my agriculture elective last term, so I'm happy to write that slide.

Speaker B: Perfect, that leaves hydroelectric dams. It's a classic renewable source, but there are lots of environmental debates about flooding valleys.

Speaker A: Since we're both really interested in the ecological impact of large dams, why don't we both research that one as well?

Speaker B: Actually, to save time, I think it's better if I take sole responsibility for the hydroelectric section. I've already got a couple of case studies in mind.

Speaker A: Okay, sounds good. Edward will handle the dams, and I'll focus on my parts.

Speaker C: Excellent division of labor. Let's meet again next Monday to see your final slides.

Speaker B: Thanks, Fiona!

This is the end of Part 3.

PART 4

You will hear a university lecturer named Grace giving a talk on the history and archaeological significance of ancient lighthouses. You now have some time to look at questions 31 to 40.

Speaker A: Good morning, everyone. In today's lecture, we're going to explore the fascinating history of ancient lighthouses—maritime structures that played a crucial role in expanding trade and ensuring the safety of early mariners. To understand why lighthouses were developed, we must first look at how early navigation worked. In daylight, ancient sailors kept close to the shore, relying on visible coastal landmarks such as distinctive hills, cliffs, or even tall trees to guide their path and identify their position. However, nighttime navigation was infinitely more hazardous. Initially, communities began lighting simple wood fires on beaches. The primary purpose of these fires was not to guide ships into harbor, but rather to warn them of nearby rocks that could tear open a wooden hull. As maritime trade expanded, more permanent and visible signals were needed. This led to the construction of the grandest lighthouse of antiquity: the Pharos of Alexandria, built in Egypt during the third century BC. This towering structure was an engineering marvel. It was constructed primarily of massive limestone blocks, faced with white marble to make it highly visible even in the glare of the Mediterranean sun. At its peak, a fire burned continuously to provide light at night. But what about during the daytime? To ensure ships could see the lighthouse from miles away, engineers installed a giant mirror at the top. This mirror reflected sunlight, creating a bright beam that could be seen far out at sea. To keep the fire burning night and day required an immense amount of wood. Carrying this fuel to the top of a structure that stood over one hundred meters tall was a huge challenge. Instead of stairs, the architects designed a wide spiral ramp inside the core of the tower. This allowed pack animals, like donkeys, to carry heavy loads of wood all the way up to the furnace chamber. Despite its solid construction, the Pharos did not survive to the modern era. While it withstood storms and ocean waves for over a thousand years, it was eventually brought down by a series of severe earthquakes that struck the region between the tenth and fourteenth centuries, leaving only underwater ruins for modern archaeologists to explore. Following the Hellenistic period, the Roman Empire took lighthouse engineering to a continental scale. As the Romans expanded their empire, they built dozens of lighthouses—which they called phares—along the Mediterranean and Atlantic coasts. The primary goal of these structures was to secure and support their rapidly growing trade routes, which connected Rome to distant provinces in Spain, Gaul, and Britain. Remarkably, one Roman lighthouse is still fully functional today. Located in northwestern Spain, it is known as the Tower of Hercules. This lighthouse has been in continuous use since the second century AD, serving as a testament to the incredible durability of Roman masonry. But Roman lighthouses were not just practical navigational aids. They also served a political purpose. Built at the edges of the known world, these imposing towers stood as a physical symbol of Roman imperial power, reminding foreign merchants and local populations of the reach and authority of Rome. Technologically, the Romans also made significant improvements to the light source itself. Over time, they realized that burning logs was highly inefficient and produced excessive soot. They began replacing wood fires with large oil lamps. This transition not only provided a steadier and more reliable light but also significantly reduced the amount of smoke produced, which had previously obscured the signal in foggy conditions. In next week's lecture, we will look at how lighthouse design evolved during the medieval period...

This is the end of Part 4.